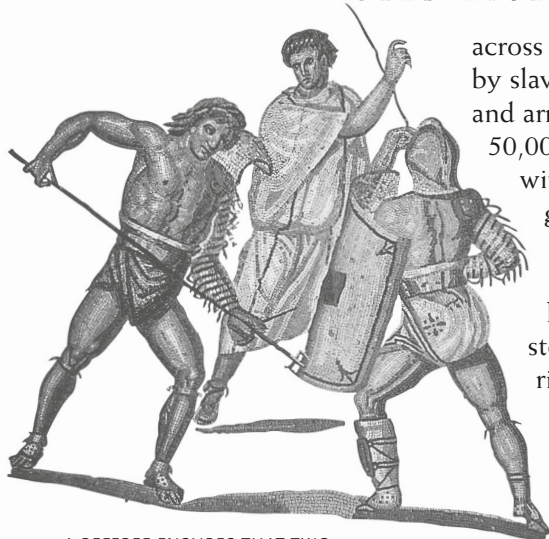




A REFEREE ENSURES THAT TWO GLADIATORS STICK TO THE RULES IN THIS MOSAIC SCENE.

across the sandy floor, followed by slaves carrying their arms and armor. The crowd of 50,000 spectators roared with delight. When the gladiators came to a halt in front of the emperor's platform, however, the cheering stopped. Raising their right hands toward the emperor, the gladiators chanted these famous Latin words: "*Ave, Imperator, morituri te salutant!*" ("Hail, Emperor, those who are about to die salute thee!").

Gladiators in action

Games held at the Colosseum followed a set pattern. The day started with animal hunts, held in the morning. The mood changed at midday, when criminals were executed. This was a preview for the highlight of the day—the gladiatorial contests held in the afternoon. At a large event, there could be hundreds of gladiators in action. Smaller shows made do with fewer fighters, a typical number being about 30.

Dressed in purple cloaks embroidered in gold, the fighters walked through the Colosseum's gladiatorial entrances. Once inside the great building, they marched

Know your enemy

In full view of the crowd, so that no one could be accused of cheating, the gladiators found out who they were to fight. The holder of the games and the gladiators' teachers decided how the warriors were to be paired, one on one. They usually matched fighters of equal ability against each other. A gladiator who had survived five fights might be paired against an opponent of the same rank. Mass fights between whole troops of gladiators were held only at the largest games.

The contest began with warm-up fights. No one got badly hurt, since only blunt